

The First Shall Be Your Slave

Please open to Luke 9, and put a marker in Matthew 19. We will be there in a moment.

Luke 9:51 says:

And it came to pass, when the time was come that he should be received up, he stedfastly set his face to go to Jerusalem,

And sent messengers before his face: and they went, and entered into a village of the Samaritans, to make ready for him.

And they did not receive him, because his face was as though he would go to Jerusalem.

And when his disciples James and John saw this, they said, Lord, wilt thou that we command fire to come down from heaven, and consume them, even as Elias did?

You know John as the author of the book of John, the disciple of love. This is the same man. The man who authored those chapters on love once said, "Lord, shall we command fire to come down from heaven and consume them?"

He operated like some of us. If most of us got even half the judgment we speak on people out of our mouths, we would be murderers.

These men were so intense they were known as the sons of thunder. They said, "They did not receive You. We tried to get lodging for the night, and they would not receive You. Should we burn them?"

How did this man go from a son of thunder to the disciple of love we know?

The Holy Spirit showed me that the message we are about to look at is the one that brought him from a son of thunder to a son of love.

Jesus must have known John had received it. Just as with Abraham, when he offered his only son and God said, "Now I know I have found someone who will keep My covenant," Jesus must have known something about John. One of the last things He did before He died was point to John and say:

Woman, behold thy son.

Son, behold thy mother.

Mary became the adopted mother of John from that day forward. Mary died of old age in John's house in Ephesus, Asia Minor, around the time of the siege of Jerusalem in A.D. 70. That was about the same time as Masada, when the Romans wanted to stamp every Jew out of existence. John took the mother of Jesus and moved to Asia Minor.

Just to show you Jesus' family, someone once said to Him, "Your mother and Your brothers are outside. They desire to see You." He answered, "Who is My mother, and who are My brothers? Those who hear the Word of God and keep it."

Is it not interesting that Mary was not committed to any of Jesus' natural brothers? He committed her to John.

Why? He must have seen something in him.

John took Mary to Ephesus, the place to which Paul wrote that great fifth chapter of Ephesians on husbands and wives. That church had to know about the family, because Paul used the family and a man's love for his wife to teach on the love Jesus has for the church.

Ephesus may have been short in some things, but evidently they understood the marriage covenant. Paul used it to illustrate the great covering Jesus has for the church. He is the church's great Provider. He wanted us to understand that relationship: the man's love for his wife, the oneness of their flesh, the man's covering, and Jesus as the covering and Provider for the church.

That is why in 1 Corinthians 11, when Paul talked about a woman praying or prophesying with her head uncovered, dishonoring her head, he meant she was not being covered by her husband, and the head she dishonored was Christ. He was talking about disorder in the home, a woman rising up and taking over the family and her husband, refusing to let him have his position in God.

Likewise, a man praying or prophesying with his head uncovered dishonors his head, Christ, because he has laid down his manhood and forced a woman to support the family. That is highly dishonoring to Christ, because Jesus as the Provider of the church would never dream of letting one need of yours go.

Jesus took Mary to a church that knew about family. I am sure, in that relationship where she lived and died, He had these things in mind. Where would Jesus send His own mother except to a place that understood that kind of family relationship?

After her death, John was banished to the Isle of Patmos, a penal colony off Turkey. At about a hundred years old, he was working in a mine when the book of Revelation came to him. He outlived the emperor who banished him, came back, and was still preaching to the churches in Asia Minor when he was well over a hundred years old.

I would say he was doing okay. He grew a little since the beginning of his ministry, when he wanted to burn villages.

What kind of message could bring a man from thunder into the one lifetime position of being charged to care for Jesus' mother in the natural for the rest of her days?

Luke 9:53 says:

And they did not receive him, because his face was as though he would go to Jerusalem.
And when his disciples James and John saw this, they said, Lord, wilt thou that we command fire to come down from heaven, and consume them, even as Elias did?
But he turned, and rebuked them, and said, Ye know not what manner of spirit ye are of.
For the Son of man is not come to destroy men's lives, but to save them.

I can remember in the formal training I received about receiving and giving. We would receive an offering from one crowd and use that offering to win another crowd. But the way some received from the first crowd just about destroyed that crowd.

One day God spoke to me, "Now that you are getting some sense, I can talk to you. Do you think I would send you to that crowd to destroy that one so you could go save this one?"

One interesting thing I discovered from the Old Testament is that God loved the nations at war against Israel as much as He loved Israel. Whether He was judging a nation or exalting it, He did it for the good of the people. He did everything for the Gentile nations for their good. There was no one He did not love.

If He finally sent His Son into the world not to condemn it, do you see Him jumping up and down saying, "Stamp out all those heathen"? No. How He acted toward the heathen was as good for the heathen as how He acted toward Israel.

He sent His Son into the world not to condemn it, but that the world through Him might be saved. Then He said:

He that believeth not is condemned already.

How could He send His Son to condemn a world already condemned? He sent Him to give the world a way out.

You cannot tell me He did not love the Gentile nations as much as He loved Israel. He did. He said, "I did not come to destroy these Samaritans. You do not know what spirit you are of. I came to save them."

If He wanted to save them after the cross, you can rest assured He wanted to save them before the cross. He did not specialize salvation for the two thousand years that followed the cross. If He saved anybody in hope of the promise in the Old Testament, He wanted to save everybody.

When I counsel people who lose a baby or suffer something they do not understand, I tell them, "I can promise you this: if you will not accuse God in all your hurt and loss, if you will not shake your fist in His face and say, 'Why, God?' but will worship Him, love Him, and trust Him, there will come a time when He will be able to show you why."

One of the hardest things is facing the responsibility of faith and the promises He has given us. He has taken nothing from me. He has taken no child from me. He has taken no brother or sister that He did not come and take with God's blessing.

As hard as it hurts in the growing process, I have had to face the responsibility. He wanted me to be healed. He did not want to take them. He wanted nobody to die before their time.

For me to grow beyond all that, eventually I will have to understand it. But right now, what I can have is trust and grace.

I trust Him.

When you love Him, worship Him, and trust Him, eventually He will be able to show you why. There are many things that had been on the shelf that He has been able to reveal to me, especially since He taught me extended worship. I understand things now that I never had before.

If this message can bring John from a son of thunder to a son of love, I would like to know what Jesus said.

Go to Matthew 19. We were teaching on this last week. Matthew 19:23 says:

Then said Jesus unto his disciples, Verily I say unto you, That a rich man shall hardly enter into the kingdom of heaven.

And again I say unto you, It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle, than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of God.

When his disciples heard it, they were exceedingly amazed, saying, Who then can be saved?

But Jesus beheld them, and said unto them, With men this is impossible; but with God all things are possible.

That placed them in a dilemma. Jesus beheld them, meaning He looked intently on them and loved them, and said, "With men this is impossible, but with God all things are possible." In other words, you are scheduled for a change of nature.

Then Peter said:

Behold, we have forsaken all, and followed thee; what shall we have therefore?

What do we get out of it?

Jesus said:

Verily I say unto you, That ye which have followed me, in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of his glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel.

Those disciples who followed Him are exactly there now: sitting on those twelve thrones. Too many have testified to seeing them there.

Peter wanted to know what they would get. Jesus said that if they forsook all and followed Him, they would sit on thrones with Him and administer judgment.

At first I thought there were only twelve thrones and they were already spoken for. But at the end of this teaching He says:

Many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first.

It does not matter what age you live in. It is what you do to cause yourself to be chosen. There are thrones out of sight for distance, still waiting to be occupied by people who will reign and rule with Him through the ages to come.

That was good for the twelve. But I used to think, "I am a Gentile. I was born in this generation. They told me all this stuff passed away. What do we get?"

Verse 29 answers:

And every one that hath forsaken houses, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my name's sake, shall receive an hundredfold, and shall inherit everlasting life.

Have you noticed what you receive a hundredfold in this life? Houses, brothers, sisters, fathers, mothers, children, and lands, but not a hundredfold in wives. And you inherit eternal life.

Then He makes this statement:

But many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first.

He did not change the subject. Matthew 20:16 says:

So the last shall be first, and the first last: for many be called, but few chosen.

Obviously, John made himself chosen, and Jesus knew before John was born again that he would do it, otherwise He would not have committed His mother to him.

What caused John to go from a son of thunder to the adopted son of Jesus' own mother? When Jesus said the first will be last and the last first, many called and few chosen, John must have found out what he needed to do to make himself chosen.

This is the message.

It does not matter what generation you were born in: the first century after His ascension, five hundred years ago, or now. There are first positions to be held, and there are last positions. He is no respecter of persons. What was available to any man is still available to you. Their time has passed, and you still have a shot at it.

Matthew 20:17 says:

And Jesus going up to Jerusalem took the twelve disciples apart in the way, and said unto them,

Behold, we go up to Jerusalem; and the Son of man shall be betrayed unto the chief priests and unto the scribes, and they shall condemn him to death,

And shall deliver him to the Gentiles to mock, and to scourge, and to crucify him: and the third day he shall rise again.

Matthew did not record it, but Peter jumped up and said, "Oh no, we are not going to let You die." Jesus said, "Get behind Me, Satan."

Then verse 20 says:

Then came to him the mother of Zebedee's children with her sons, worshipping him, and desiring a certain thing of him.

And he said unto her, What wilt thou? She saith unto him, Grant that these my two sons may sit, the one on thy right hand, and the other on the left, in thy kingdom.

The mother of James and John, the sons of thunder, came with her sons standing right there. She was jostling for position.

People say she did not know what kind of kingdom He was coming into. I used to think she was jostling for a natural throne when Jesus would come as the conquering Lion and rule Jerusalem naturally. But I believe now she knew He was talking about the spiritual kingdom, because He had just told them He would be delivered to the chief priests, mocked, scourged, put to death, and raised on the third day.

She wanted a throne on each side of Him for her two sons.

Jesus answered:

Ye know not what ye ask. Are ye able to drink of the cup that I shall drink of, and to be baptized with the baptism that I am baptized with?

They said:

We are able.

The cup He was talking about is described in verse 28:

Even as the Son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give his life a ransom for many.

He asked, "Are you willing to drink this cup?"

They said, "We are able."

He said:

Ye shall drink indeed of my cup, and be baptized with the baptism that I am baptized with: but to sit on my right hand, and on my left, is not mine to give, but it shall be given to them for whom it is prepared of my Father.

When the other ten heard it, they were moved with indignation against the two brothers. They were probably getting fed up with the actions of the sons of thunder and their mother.

Jesus called them to Himself and settled the skirmish quickly.

Jesus said:

Ye know that the princes of the Gentiles exercise dominion over them, and they that are great exercise authority upon them.

But it shall not be so among you: but whosoever will be great among you, let him be your minister;

And whosoever will be chief among you, let him be your servant:

Even as the Son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give his life a ransom for many.

The princes of the Gentiles rule by force, with an iron hand: obey me or I will kill you. Jesus said that is not how you get position or authority in the kingdom of God. It does not work that way.

Whoever will be great among you, let him be your servant. The word translated "minister" there means servant.

You do not get rank by force in the kingdom. You do not get it by exalting yourself. The trail to greatness and great authority is the road of servanthood.

The first will be last, and the last first. Many are called, but few are chosen. It does not matter who you are until you take the road of the servant. You will not have greatness or authority in the kingdom.

I do not care about exposure. That is not the game. I do not care if your face is on television. That does not mean you have reward in His book.

Are you a servant?

Jesus did not stop at the level of servant as ministry. You do not have to be in the fivefold ministry to be a minister. The great ones serve their brethren.

But there is an even higher call. It does not matter whether I or you carry the title apostle, prophet, teacher, pastor, or evangelist. There is a higher call than all those callings, available to anyone who will answer the call to be a servant.

If you fulfill the call to the servant, to the next level, there is a higher call than ministry. If you can make it, one of those thrones will be yours.

Verse 26 says:

Whosoever will be great among you, let him be your minister.

Verse 27 says:

And whosoever will be chief among you, let him be your servant.

The word for chief is the same word translated first in verse 16:

So the last shall be first, and the first last: for many be called, but few chosen.

There is even a higher call than greatness. Whoever will be chief, whoever will be first among you, let him be your servant. The word translated servant there means slave.

He who comes in first here and there must become your slave.

What is the definition of slave? We do not have to go far to find it:

And every one that hath forsaken houses, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my name's sake, shall receive an hundredfold, and shall inherit everlasting life.

They follow Him and serve only Him.

This is what caused the son of thunder to become a son of love. John obtained one of those first places. He and James were listening to every word. Jesus said, "You want to be first? Then become a slave."

Look at the Son of Man. He did not come to be ministered to. He came to minister, to be a slave, to be a servant. He took the lowest position.

He cried in Psalm 22:

I am a worm, and no man.

He was exalted to the highest position at the right hand of the Father. He took the sins of the world. He took the lowest position.

Many who are first will be last, and those last will be first. Many are called, but few are chosen.

All of you are called to fulfill your calling with that kind of love. Very few are chosen for that kind of reward.

Why? Because those who make themselves first, exalt themselves, serve themselves, and consume everything on themselves come in last. Those who make themselves last, the servants and slaves, come in first.

By the end of his life, John had obviously become that.

One Tuesday night, as I was getting ready to minister to the outreach, He said to me:

"Son, your word is no better to Me than it is to a fellow minister, servant, person, or sinner."

Some of you have trouble with faith because your word is no good.

He said, "Your word is no better to Me than it is to another person."

You want to argue, "Yes, it is."

He said, "No, it is not. The lower the stature of the person, the more heaven esteems your word to them, because you have nothing to gain back from them. The less esteemed they are, the higher heaven honors you when you keep your word to them."

Things are backwards in heaven.

This is why, when Jesus talked about exaltation, He said you would have worship in the presence of those you eat meat with. Then He began to teach them that when you invite people to come to the kingdom of God, do not invite only your rich neighbors, kinsmen, and relatives. If you invite only those who have the means to do something for you, then your motivation is that they will benefit you.

When you call people to come to His supper, if you differentiate, you are not much of a servant, and you are certainly not His slave.

A slave can be dropped off at one end of the Amazon. He does not need to boast of anything. By the time he gets to the other end, he is still His slave. I do not need anything but Him to document that I am His son.

Most of what we have is His; just do not ask Him to prove it.

When you invite people to come to His supper, go get the halt, the maimed, the lame, and the blind. You are a minister of His table. God has prepared this table through Jesus Christ. Call them to come and eat, because at His table the lame do not have to be lame anymore, and the blind do not have to be blind anymore.

"Go get them and bring them, boy. If you are My slave, you will minister to them what the lame and the blind need."

He said:

Thou shalt be recompensed at the resurrection of the just.

Oh, you will be recompensed.

He will say, "Sit over here." He will trust you to rule over spiritual things, because the standard was not set wrongly when you served Him here. He will trust you over the lives of millions because you were purged from hurting them.

John heard that message. He went from a son of thunder to a son of love, trusted with Jesus' mother.

What a message for Mother's Day.